A First Look at Open Computer and Software Inventory–Next Generation (OCS-NG)

OCS inventory NG is cross-platform software, which supports most OSs. It is based on the popular LAMP or WAMP solutions stack. Using a standardised Web interface of HTTP protocols, the network agents communicate with the management server via XML protocols. By deploying it, the systems admin's job can be made much easier.

OCS-NG is designed to ease the systems admin's job of managing the inventory and updating information about hardware. Licensed under GPL, it is available in 11 languages. It is also available for various flavours of Linux, Windows, Solaris, HP-UNIX, AIX and Mac OS. And it even has an option called 'Remote deployment of software'. The unique feature of OCS-NG is auto rebuild. If your asset database gets corrupted and you have no backups, OCS-NG will rebuild it by re-collecting the data from agents through locally stored data.

OCS-NG consists of four major components that are listed below.

Administrative console: This can be accessed via an Internet browser, to manage the OCS-NG inventory. Usually, it will query the data from the database server.

Communication server: This manages the communication between agents and the database server via http.

Database server: Actual data is stored here. The default database is MySQL.

Deployment server: This is used to store deployment configurations and it works using https for high security.

All the components can be installed on a single server or on multiple servers. The best combination will be a DB server + a communication server and admin server + a console server. Figure 1 gives the communication methodology and architecture of OCS-NG. For high availability (HA) purposes we can use the admin server as the backup database server. If you have a small number of computers, e.g., 200+ nodes, you can deploy all components on a single server which has 4GB RAM running on Linux. If you choose multiple servers, Linux is preferred.

Let's look at the pre-requisites for each component. I tried testing OCS by installing all the modules in one CentOS 5.6 server. The following are installation/configuration examples, with a single server installation of OCSNG 2.1.2.

Preparing the servers/components

a. ***Database server:*** For MySQL 4.1 or greater with InnoDB engine active, run the following commands:

```
# yum install mysql-server
# service mysqld start
# chkconfig mysqld on
```

To check whether the InnoDB engine is active or not,